

Contents

1 A local Old English sequence from allophony to weak-tail reduction	2
1.1 Introduction	2
2 B allophony and Sievers-law syncope	2
2.1 Historical discussion of B allophony	2
2.2 SC049. Distribution of <i>*b</i> after vowels and liquids (PGmcBAllophony)	3
2.3 Historical discussion of Sievers-law syncope	3
2.4 SC050. Sievers-law syncope (SieversLawSyncope)	3
3 Palatalization of <i>*sk</i> to <i>*sc</i>	5
3.1 Historical discussion	5
3.2 SC051. Palatalization of <i>*sk</i> to <i>*sc</i> (OESkPalatalization)	5
4 Velar palatalization before front vowels	6
4.1 Historical discussion	6
4.2 SC052. Palatalization of <i>*k</i> before front vowels and <i>*j</i> (OEVelarPalatalizationKFront)	6
4.3 SC052. Velar palatalization before front vowels (OEVelarPalatalization)	7
5 Post-velar <i>*w</i>-loss and loss of <i>*w</i> before final <i>*i</i>	9
5.1 Historical discussion of early <i>*w</i> -loss before umlaut	9
5.2 SC053. Loss of <i>*w</i> after velars (OEPostVelarWLoss)	9
5.3 SC054. Loss of <i>*w</i> before final <i>*i</i> (OEWLossBeforeI)	9
6 The Old English i-umlaut and West Saxon palatal diphthongization	11
6.1 Historical discussion of i-umlaut and West Saxon palatal diphthongization	11
6.2 SC055. Fronting under i-umlaut (OEIUmlautFronting)	11
6.3 SC055. Raising under i-umlaut (OEIUmlautRaising)	12
6.4 SC055. Diphthongal outcomes under i-umlaut (OEIUmlautDiphthong)	12
6.5 SC055. The composite i-umlaut rule (OEIUmlaut)	13
6.6 SC056. West Saxon palatal diphthongization (OEWsPalatalDiphthongization)	13
7 J-cluster coalescence	15
7.1 Historical discussion	15
7.2 SC057. Coalescence of velar + <i>*j</i> clusters (OEJClusterCoalescence)	15
8 Nasal dissimilation	16
8.1 Historical discussion	16
8.2 SC058. Nasal dissimilation in short-vowel environments (OENasalDissimilation)	16
9 Back mutation	18
9.1 Historical discussion	18
9.2 SC059. Back mutation before labials and liquids (OEBackMutation)	18
10 West Saxon palatal umlaut	19
10.1 Historical discussion	19
10.2 SC060. West Saxon palatal umlaut before <i>*h</i> -clusters (OEWsPalatalUmlaut)	19
11 Weak-tail nasal loss	20
11.1 Historical discussion	20
11.2 SC061. Reduction of final nasal weak-tail endings (OEWeakTailNasalLoss)	20
12 High-vowel apocope	21
12.1 Historical discussion	21
12.2 SC063. High-vowel apocope after heavy syllables and in trisyllables (OEHighVowelApocope)	21
13 Post-apocope <i>*n</i>-loss and medial syncope	23
13.1 Historical discussion of post-apocope <i>*n</i> -loss and medial syncope	23
13.2 SC064. Loss of stem-final <i>*n</i> after long <i>*ī</i> (NWGmcInStemNLoss)	23

13.3 SC065. Medial syncope before dentals after heavy syllables (OEMedialSyncope) . .	23
14 Late syncope and degemination	24
14.1 Historical discussion of late syncope and degemination	24
14.2 SC066. L-adjacent syncope in medial syllables (OELAdjacentSyncope)	24
14.3 SC067. Dental assimilation in newly formed clusters (OEDentalAssimilation) . .	24
14.4 SC068. Preconsonantal degemination before sonorants (OEPreconsonantalDegemination)	25
15 Early o-shortening	26
15.1 Historical discussion	26
15.2 SC069. Early shortening of unstressed * <i>ō</i> before nasals (OEEarlyOShortening) . .	26
16 Early unstressed fronting and later o-shortening	27
16.1 Historical discussion of early unstressed fronting and later o-shortening	27
16.2 SC070. Early fronting of unstressed * <i>a</i> (OEUnstressedFrontingEarly)	27
16.3 SC071. Later shortening of unstressed * <i>ō</i> (OELateOShortening)	27
17 Unstressed long-vowel shortening and ae-merger	29
17.1 Historical discussion of unstressed long-vowel shortening and ae-merger	29
17.2 SC072. Shortening of unstressed long vowels (OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening)	29
17.3 SC073. Merger of unstressed * <i>æ</i> with * <i>e</i> (OEUnstressedAEMerger)	29
18 Medial unstressed-i lowering	31
18.1 Historical discussion of medial unstressed-i lowering and * <i>ng</i> retention	31
18.2 SC074. First medial unstressed-i lowering (OEMedUnstressedILowering1)	31
18.3 SC075. Preservation of medial unstressed * <i>i</i> before * <i>ng</i> (OEMedUnstressedILowering)	31
19 Prefix i-reduction	33
19.1 Historical discussion	33
19.2 SC076. Reduction of prefixal * <i>i</i> in unstressed position (OEPrefixIReduction) . . .	33
20 Weak-tail reduction	34
20.1 Historical discussion	34
20.2 SC078. Reduction of remaining weak-tail vowels (OEWeakTailReduction)	34
21 References	35

1 A local Old English sequence from allophony to weak-tail reduction

1.1 Introduction

This section follows an ordered stretch of Old English sound changes from labial allophony and Sievers-law syncope through palatalization, umlaut, back mutation, high-vowel apocope, post-apocope reduction, later syncope and degemination, unstressed-vowel shortening and merger, medial unstressed-i lowering, prefix-vowel reduction, and weak-tail reduction.

The chapters vary in scale. Some describe large vowel or consonant developments; others record narrower adjustments whose value lies in the lexical breakpoints they fix within the finite-state cascade.

2 B allophony and Sievers-law syncope

2.1 Historical discussion of B allophony

The first change is the positional alternation of Germanic **b*. Hogg states the Old English distribution clearly: /*b*/ is a stop initially, after nasals, and in gemination, while the same segment is otherwise realized as a voiced bilabial fricative (Hogg 1992, 101–2). Ringe and Taylor support

the broader West Germanic background by treating Proto-West-Germanic **b* as a segment whose stop and fricative values depend on position (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 121), and Luick’s spelling evidence shows the same labial fricative pattern in Old English (Luick 1914–1940, 107).

This is a narrow consonantal distribution with limited independent scope, but it matters because later derivations already assume that the alternation is in place.

2.2 SC049. Distribution of **b* after vowels and liquids (PGmcBAllophony)

The first rule formalizes the stop-fricative alternation of Germanic **b*.

```
define PGmcBAllophony [
  { *b } -> { *β } || PGmcStarVocalic _ ,
  { *b } -> { *β } || [{ *l } | { *r } ] _
] .o. [
  { *β } -> { *b } || _ { *b }
];
```

In prose, the rule says that **b* becomes a fricative after vowels and liquids, while geminate **bb* keeps the stop value.

Historically, this is the sort of narrow distributional statement that the handbooks place within the consonant system and discuss only briefly on its own. Even so, it matters because later derivations assume that the alternation is already in place. The clearest tested consequence appears in *reǵnboga* ‘rainbow’. If the rule is moved before the earlier linking-vowel adjustment, the derivation yields *reǵnfoga* ‘rainbow’ rather than expected OE *reǵnboga* ‘rainbow’. This shows that SC037 OECompoundLinkingSyncope must come before SC049 PGmcBAllophony. No equally sharp later lexical breakpoint emerges within the tested sequence, so the rule has no explicit later boundary within the present sequence.

2.3 Historical discussion of Sievers-law syncope

Sievers’ Law belongs to a different historical problem. It is a prosodic and morphological adjustment in heavy stems, not a distributional allophone of a stop consonant. Adamczyk treats the Old English reflexes of the law as real historical material in weak verbs and related formations (Adamczyk 2001, 61–72). Fulk gives the compact comparative summary through familiar forms such as *biddan* ‘ask’, *sellan* ‘give’, and *nerian* ‘save’ (Fulk 2018, 127, §6.15).

That makes the change historically narrower but chronologically important. It is the last small feeder before the palatalization sequence begins in earnest, and its place in the cascade is clearer than that of the preceding allophony rule.

2.4 SC050. Sievers-law syncope (SieversLawSyncope)

The second rule removes the Sievers-law **i* before **j* after a consonant.

```
define SieversLawSyncope [
  { *i } -> 0 || [EnglishStarConsonant | EnglishPalatalConsonant] _ { *j }
];
```

In plain language, the rule contracts the heavier **-CijV-** sequence to **-CjV-**. That is why it belongs to the historical aftermath of Sievers’ Law and stands apart from the earlier stop-fricative distribution.

Its place in the sequence is clearer than that of the allophony rule. If the change is delayed until after SC052 OEVelarPalatalization, the cluster behind *streccan* ‘stretch’ is affected too late. With PGmc **strákkijanq* in the wrong order, the derivation yields *streccan* ‘stretch’. The expected Old English form is *streccan* ‘stretch’. That is a real chronological consequence. No equally precise earlier lexical breakpoint fixes how far back the syncope must stand, so the historical picture remains asymmetric. The rule is secure as an immediate feeder into the palatalization zone, even

though its earlier limit is less sharply bounded. The evidence therefore places SC050 SieversLaw-Syncope before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization.

3 Palatalization of **sk* to **sc*

3.1 Historical discussion

The palatalization of **sk* to Old English **sc* is one of the recognizable early cluster changes in the larger palatalization zone. Campbell distinguishes the cluster from plain velars when he remarks that **sk* is especially prone to palatalization and assibilation (Campbell 1959, 278, §440). Hogg gives the same change a clearer structural place by treating **sk* beside the palatalization of plain velars and before the later West Saxon diphthongal developments (Hogg 1992, 106–7, 111–12). Ringe and Taylor make the same sequence explicit when they distinguish the earlier palatalization of velars and **sk* from the later diphthongization after already palatal consonants (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 213–16, §§6.4.1, 6.5.1).

Luick is especially useful for the larger frame. He treats the cluster change as part of a broader early movement toward palatal articulation, while still allowing later vowel consequences to form a different chapter of the history (Luick 1914–1940, 157, §168). Fulk’s summary is the most concise warning against overextension: Old English **sc* is palatal except in the well-known back-vowel environments that preserve harder outcomes (Fulk 2018, 28). The result is a historically clear rule, but not an excuse to merge the whole palatalization and umlaut region into one undivided chapter.

3.2 SC051. Palatalization of **sk* to **sc* (OESkPalatalization)

The implementation states the **sk* rule explicitly.

```
define OESkPalatalization [  
  {*s} {*k} -> {*ʃ} || .#. _  
] .o. [  
  {*s} {*k} -> {*ʃ} || EnglishStarFrontVowel _ (EnglishStarConsonant | .#. )  
] .o. [  
  {*s} {*k} -> {*ʃ} || (EnglishStarConsonant | .#. ) _ EnglishStarFrontVowel  
] .o. [  
  {*s} {*k} -> {*ʃ} || _ {*j}  
] .o. [  
  {*s} {*k} -> {*ʃ} || {*j} _  
];
```

In prose, the rule turns **sk* into a palatal outcome in the environments that lead to Old English **sc*.

Its historical place is between the earlier restoration and the later palatal vowel developments. If it is moved too early, the forms behind *flasce* ‘flask’ and *wascan* ‘wash’ are fronted too soon, yielding *flæsce* ‘flask’ and *wæscan* ‘wash’ rather than expected OE *flasce* and *wascan*. This gives the earlier result. This shows that SC046 OEARestoration must come before SC051 OESkPalatalization. If it is moved too late, the cluster no longer feeds the later West-Saxon diphthongal outcomes that appear in *sceaft* ‘shaft’, *scēar* ‘shear’, *scēap* ‘sheath’, *scēap* ‘sheep’, and *sciold* ‘shield’. That is why the rule sits naturally beside SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization.

No single later wrong form is isolated for the whole group of **scea-** / **scie-** witnesses, but the current notes do show that the cluster must already be palatalized before the later West-Saxon diphthongal rule applies. This places SC051 OESkPalatalization before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization.

The narrower chapter shape matters. The cluster rule is real and historically visible, but it is still only one part of the broader palatalizing sequence. The change should therefore be read as a distinct cluster development inside that sequence, not as a complete account of Old English palatalization.

4 Velar palatalization before front vowels

4.1 Historical discussion

Luick places the change inside a broad early palatalizing movement. Under the heading “Frühe Verschiebungen in palataler Richtung,” he treats English *k* and *g* before bright vowels together with the larger field of palatal effects (Luick 1914–1940, 157, §168). His emphasis falls on the environment first: velars before bright vowels and in the vicinity of the palatal glide belong to one early phonological sequence. The examples associated with that sequence, such as *ceaster* ‘town’, *geaf* ‘gave’, *giefan* ‘give’, and *giest* ‘guest’, already show that consonantal palatalization and later vowel effects stand close together historically, even when they must be distinguished analytically (Luick 1914–1940, 157–67, §§168–182).

Campbell narrows the picture by distinguishing plain velars from the especially palatal-prone *sk* cluster. His remark that “[*sk*] is more prone to palatalization and assibilation than [*k*]” is brief, but it makes clear that different members of the larger palatal field need not behave identically (Campbell 1959, 278, §440). Elsewhere in the same part of the grammar he uses forms such as *cild* ‘child’, *dæg* ‘day’, *giefan* ‘give’, and *giest* ‘guest’, which show how palatalized velars, palatal influence, and later umlautal outcomes meet in the same region of the lexicon without collapsing into one process (Campbell 1959, 69–72, 89, §§170, 190–191).

Hogg makes the conditioning sharper still. He states that the change takes place when the velar consonant is adjacent to and in the same syllable as a front vowel or the palatal consonant *j* (Hogg 1992, 103–4). This formulation is important because it moves the discussion from a broad list of palatal outcomes to a more precise phonological environment involving adjacency and syllable structure.

Ringe and Taylor make the chronological relation still clearer. When they write that “after initial velars and **sk* had been palatalized” West-Saxon diphthongization follows, plain velar palatalization becomes an earlier consonantal stage presupposed by later vowel developments (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 215, §6.5.1). Their own examples of the plain-velar rule, such as *weccan* ‘wake’, *licgan* ‘lie’, *lecgan* ‘lay’, *secg* ‘retainer’, *ecg* ‘edge’, *wicg* ‘horse’, and *brycg* ‘bridge’, illustrate the same point in lexical detail: front vowels and *j* create the palatal environment in which plain *k* and *g* cease to behave as plain velars (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 213–14, §6.4.1).

Taken together, these accounts show a gradual tightening of focus. Luick treats palatalization as a broad early movement. Campbell distinguishes more sharply between plain velars and the *sk* complex. Hogg specifies the adjacency and syllable conditions more directly. Ringe and Taylor then place the plain velar change in an explicit sequence that leads forward to later West-Saxon diphthongization. The literature therefore supports two claims at once: the change belongs to a larger palatalizing environment, and it must be kept distinct from neighboring processes if the sequence of developments is to be described accurately.

4.2 SC052. Palatalization of **k* before front vowels and **j* (OEVelarPalatalizationKFront)

The first part of the implementation isolates the *k*-side environments of the change.

```
define OEVelarPalatalizationKFront [
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || .#. _ EnglishStarFrontVowel,
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || _ [{*i} | {*ī}],
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || _ {*í},
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || [{*i} | {*ī}] _ EnglishStarFrontVowel,
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || {*í} _ EnglishStarFrontVowel,
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || [{*i} | {*ī}] _ .#. ,
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || {*í} _ .#.
] .o. [
  {*k} {*k} -> {*tʃ} {*tʃ} || _ {*j}
] .o. [
  {*k} -> {*tʃ} || _ {*j}
] ;
```

In prose, the rule turns plain *k* into a palatal outcome before front vowels and *j*, including the geminated environment before *j*.

Historically, this section corresponds to the core of the older discussion of palatalized velars. It captures the environments behind forms such as *weccan* ‘wake’, *licgan* ‘lie’, and *leccan* ‘lay’, where front vowels or *j* trigger the palatal outcome in the first place (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 213–14, §6.4.1). It is also the part of the process that prepares forms later assumed by SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and, farther on, by SC055 OEIUmlautFronting.

Within the present implementation, this helper rule is not ordered separately from the broader velar-palatalization rule below. Its chronology is therefore that of the larger rule it feeds. If the palatalization complex is moved before Sievers-law syncope, PGmc **strákkijanȝ* yields *strecȝan* ‘stretch’ rather than expected OE *streċȝan* ‘stretch’. If it is delayed beyond the umlautal core, PGmc **kūi* and **lúnganjō* yield *cȳ* ‘cows’ and *lunȝen* ‘lungs’ rather than expected OE *cȳ* and *lunȝen*. The shared boundary pattern is therefore clear. SC050 SieversLawSyncope must come before SC052 OEVelarPalatalizationKFront, and the palatalization complex must in turn come before SC055 OEIUmlautFronting.

4.3 SC052. Velar palatalization before front vowels (OEVelarPalatalization)

The broader rule adds the *g* environments and composes them with the *k* palatalization rule above.

```
define OEVelarPalatalization [
  OEVelarPalatalizationKFront
] .o. [
  { *g } -> { *ȝ } || _ EnglishStarFrontVowel,
  { *g } -> { *ȝ } || EnglishStarFrontVowel _ .#.,
  { *g } -> { *ȝ } || EnglishStarFrontVowel _ EnglishStarFrontVowel,
  { *g } -> { *ȝ } || EnglishStarFrontVowel _ [EnglishStarConsonant - { *j }],
  { *g } { *g } -> { *ȝ } { *ȝ } || _ { *j }
] .o. [
  { *g } -> { *ȝ } || _ { *j }
];
```

In prose, the rule palatalizes plain *k* and *g* in front-vocalic and *j*-adjacent environments. Writing it as a separate rule clarifies the relative order of plain-velar palatalization, *sk*-palatalization, and umlautal developments.

The rule belongs after the earlier syncope that prepares forms like *streċȝan* ‘stretch’ and before the later umlautal rules that would otherwise over-palatalize forms such as *cȳ* ‘cows’ and *lunȝen* ‘lungs’. See SC055 OEIUmlautFronting and SC055 OEIUmlaut below.

If the rule is moved too early, before the syncope that prepares the consonant cluster, it breaks the derivation that should yield *streċȝan* ‘stretch’. With PGmc **strákkijanȝ* in the wrong order, the model produces *strecȝan* ‘stretch’; the expected Old English form is *streċȝan* ‘stretch’.

If it is moved too late, after *i*-umlaut, it over-palatalizes forms such as *cȳ* ‘cows’ and *lunȝen* ‘lungs’. PGmc **kūi* then yields *cȳ* ‘cows’; the expected form is *cȳ* ‘cows’. PGmc **lúnganjō* yields *lunȝen* ‘lungs’; the expected form is *lunȝen* ‘lungs’.

These lexical failures show that SC050 SieversLawSyncope must come before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and that SC052 OEVelarPalatalization must come before SC055 OEIUmlaut.

Once the rule is in place, plain velars before front vowels and *j* no longer remain plain. They become the palatal outcomes presupposed by later developments, including the umlautal rules discussed in SC055 OEIUmlautFronting. That matters for dictionary-like forms such as *cild* ‘child’ or *dæg* ‘day’ and for the broader relation between consonantal palatalization and later vowel-fronting processes (Luick 1914–1940, 157, §168; Campbell 1959, 278, §440; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 203–15, §§6.4.1, 6.5.1).

The evidence places the rule within a wider palatalizing environment, but it does not require every neighboring palatal process to be merged with it. *sk* belongs to a related but distinct de-

velopment, and the later umlautal material poses a different historical problem. The relation to the earlier syncope rule is likewise specific and limited: the *streccan* ‘stretch’ evidence shows a real dependency without turning the feeder process into a coequal sound law of the same scope.

5 Post-velar *w-loss and loss of *w before final *i

5.1 Historical discussion of early *w-loss before umlaut

The two rules gathered here are unequal in weight. The first is a narrow loss of *w after velars in the *ngw sequence. Ringe and Taylor make the historical core clear when they derive PGmc *singwan to Old English *singan* ‘sing’ (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 214, §6.4.2). That gives the change a real comparative anchor, but it does not turn it into a large chapter of its own. It is the kind of small local sound change that needs a place in the sequence without claiming the status of a major handbook law.

The second rule is historically more legible. Campbell notes the recurring loss of *w before *i in unstressed position (Campbell 1959, 167, §406). Ringe and Taylor trace the development of *sæ* ‘sea’ from earlier *saiwi- / *sawi- (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 257, §6.7.1), and Luick gives the same trajectory in his own historical grammar (Luick 1914–1940, 173, §187). The chapter therefore belongs in the stretch between plain palatalization and the umlautal core, but it should keep the asymmetry visible: the first rule is a narrow loss in the *ngw sequence, and the second is a stronger glide-loss development with a specific lexical witness.

5.2 SC053. Loss of *w after velars (OEPPostVelarWLoss)

The first rule handles the *ngw simplification.

```
define OEPPostVelarWLoss [  
  { *w } -> 0 || { *n } { *g } _  
];
```

In prose, the rule removes *w after the velar cluster in forms of the *singwan type.

Historically, this is a very small rule. It keeps developments such as *singan* ‘sing’ visible in the sequence, but it does not create a large family of lexical breakpoints. Current testing does not recover a positive earlier or later boundary: the search reaches older material on the left and the later Old English search limit on the right with no decisive wrong form. If the rule is moved either earlier or later within the tested sequence, no lexical witness yet provides a sharper wrong/expected pair. The safest reading is therefore modest: this is a local pre-umlaut rule that belongs before the umlautal chapter without claiming a sharper chronological slot than the evidence supports.

5.3 SC054. Loss of *w before final *i (OEWLossBeforeI)

The second rule is the more historically legible member of the pair.

```
define OEWLossBeforeI [  
  { *w } -> 0 || EnglishStarVocalic _ { *i } .#.  
];
```

In prose, the rule removes non-initial *w before final unstressed *i.

The best witness is *sæ* ‘sea’. Campbell’s discussion of the loss of *w before *i, Ringe and Taylor’s derivation from earlier *saiwi- / *sawi-, and Luick’s parallel account all point to the same historical consequence (Campbell 1959, 167, §406; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 257, §6.7.1; Luick 1914–1940, 173, §187). The glide has to disappear early enough for the preceding vowel to continue into the later fronted and lengthened outcome. If the glide survives too long, the derivation retains *w and misses *sæ* ‘sea’. If the rule is moved before SC020 PGmcFinalZDeletion, the same witness yields *sæw* ‘sea’ rather than expected OE *sæ*. This shows that SC020 PGmcFinalZDeletion must come before SC054 OEWLossBeforeI. If the rule is delayed until after SC063 OEHIGHVowelApocope, the same witness again yields *sæw* rather than expected *sæ*. This places SC054 OEWLossBeforeI before SC063 OEHIGHVowelApocope.

This is why the chapter belongs immediately before the broader umlautal developments discussed in SC055 OEIUmlaut. The two rules together form a genuine lead-in to that later vowel chapter, but only the second has a strong lexical and handbook footing of its own.

6 The Old English i-umlaut and West Saxon palatal diphthongization

6.1 Historical discussion of i-umlaut and West Saxon palatal diphthongization

Luick gives the change its traditional scale:

Der wichtigste Fall von palataler Beeinflussung ... war die Veränderung der urenglischen Vokale durch i oder j der Folgesilbe.

(Luick 1914–1940, 166–67, §182)

Campbell gives the most compact classical formulation in English when he writes that “the process known as i-umlaut or i-mutation operates on practically all the sounds which it could theoretically affect in OE” (Campbell 1959, 69, §190). He immediately defines the core conditioning environment as a following i or j, and he goes on to trace the consequences across much of the vowel system, including forms such as *giest* ‘guest’, *giefan* ‘give’, *hierde* ‘shepherd’, and *ieldra* ‘older’ (Campbell 1959, 69–72, §§190–197).

Hogg continues in the same vein: “we come now to a change which is almost as uncontroversial as it is important” (Hogg 1992, 112). His examples, such as *bryd* ‘bride’, *trymman* ‘strengthen’, *bedd* ‘bed’, *ciest* ‘chest’, and *wiersa* ‘worse’, likewise emphasize that the change is a broad redistribution of vowel quality across the Old English vowel system (Hogg 1992, 112–14).

The narrower palatal-diphthongal material is described differently. Ringe and Taylor treat West-Saxon diphthongization after initial palatals as a distinct process (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 215, §6.5.1), and Fulk is even more explicit about its chronological delicacy when he calls it “diphthongization by initial palatal consonants (which precedes front umlaut but not breaking)” (Fulk 2018, 74, §4.13). Ringe and Taylor’s examples such as *gielðan* ‘pay’, *sciold* ‘shield’, and *scieppan* ‘create’ show that this narrower process is triggered by already palatal consonants and leads to specifically West-Saxon diphthongal outputs (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 215–16, §6.5.1).

The sequence of discussion is fairly clear. Luick, Campbell, and Hogg all give i-umlaut primary importance. Ringe and Taylor and Fulk then help separate that major change from the narrower West-Saxon diphthongization that stands beside it. The literature therefore establishes a large, system-wide umlautal change and a narrower adjoining process affecting words after initial palatals. That distinction matters because the two processes act in different environments and produce different lexical consequences.

6.2 SC055. Fronting under i-umlaut (OEIUmlautFronting)

The first component of the implementation handles the broad fronting of vowels under the influence of following i or j.

```
define OEIUmlautFronting [  
  {*a} -> {*æ} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*ā} -> {*ǣ} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*e} -> {*i} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*o} -> {*e} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*ō} -> {*ē} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*u} -> {*y} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*ū} -> {*ȳ} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*á} -> {*æ} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*é} -> {*i} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*ó} -> {*e} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,  
  {*ú} -> {*y} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger  
];
```

In prose, the rule fronts and raises the relevant simple vowels when a following i or j provides the trigger.

Historically, this is the most central part of the umlaut development described by Luick, Campbell, Hogg, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk. Within the present implementation it stands after SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and before the narrower West-Saxon palatal-diphthongization rule discussed below.

The handbooks describe the same conditioning environment in different ways but with the same phonological consequence: a following high front vocoid triggers the fronting of earlier back vowels. That is why forms such as *fylgan* ‘follow’, *gylden* ‘golden’, *wyrm* ‘worm’, and *giest* ‘guest’ can all be treated inside the same formal rule even though they belong to different lexical classes (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 222, §6.6.1; Campbell 1959, 69–72, §§190–191).

The same ordering logic that governs the umlaut complex governs this component. If the umlaut rule set is moved before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization, PGmc **kūi* yields *cȳ* ‘cows’ rather than expected OE *cȳ*, and **lúnganjō* yields *lunġen* ‘lungs’ rather than expected OE *lungen*. At the other edge, the later West-Saxon diphthongization must follow the umlaut rule set: if that later rule is moved too early, PGmc **gēftiz* yields *ġieft* ‘gift’ rather than expected OE *ġift*, and **skáiθiz* yields *scāþ* ‘sheath’ rather than expected *scēaþ*. This shows that SC052 OEVelarPalatalization must come before SC055 OEIUmlautFronting, and that SC055 OEIUmlautFronting must come before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization.

As a component rule, it shares the chronology of SC055 OEIUmlaut.

6.3 SC055. Raising under i-umlaut (OEIUmlautRaising)

The second component handles the raising of umlauted æ to e.

```
define OEIUmlautRaising [
  {*æ} -> {*e} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger
];
```

In plain language, this rule takes the fronted low vowel created by the earlier fronting rule and raises it further where the same umlaut trigger still holds.

Historically, this belongs inside the same broad i-umlaut development. It is part of the same chronological development and shares the evidence base of SC055 OEIUmlaut.

Like the fronting component, this raising rule falls between SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization. If the umlaut complex is moved before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization, **kūi* yields *cȳ* instead of expected *cȳ* and **lúnganjō* yields *lunġen* instead of expected *lungen*. If the later West-Saxon diphthongization is moved too early, **gēftiz* yields *ġieft* rather than expected *ġift*, and **skáiθiz* yields *scāþ* rather than expected *scēaþ*.

These outcomes show that SC052 OEVelarPalatalization must come before SC055 OEIUmlautRaising, and that SC055 OEIUmlautRaising must come before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization.

This narrower subrule matters because the sources do not describe umlaut as simple fronting alone. Campbell explicitly notes that the low front vowel changes again before *m* and *n* in most dialects (Campbell 1959, 69, §190), and Hogg likewise treats short front vowels as part of the same assimilatory system (Hogg 1992, 112).

6.4 SC055. Diphthongal outcomes under i-umlaut (OEIUmlautDiphthong)

The third component handles the diphthongal outcomes that also undergo i-umlaut.

```
define OEIUmlautDiphthong [
  {*ea} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
  {*ēa} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
  {*io} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
  {*īo} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
  {*eo} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
  {*ēo} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
  {*ēa} -> {*ie} || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
```

```

    { *éo } -> { *ie } || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger,
    { *io } -> { *ie } || _ EnglishIUmlautIntervening EnglishIUmlautTrigger
];

```

In prose, the rule states that diphthongal inputs are subject to umlaut as well: the vowel change is not confined to simple vowels.

This matters historically because the handbooks describe i-umlaut as a system-wide assimilatory development. The rule therefore stands inside the same chronological bracket as SC055 OEIUmlautFronting and SC055 OEIUmlautRaising, even though its outputs are shaped differently.

The relevant examples are the recurring West-Saxon *ie* forms cited in the handbooks, including *giest* ‘guest’, *giefan* ‘give’, and *hierde* ‘shepherd’ in Campbell and *ciest* ‘chest’ in Hogg (Campbell 1959, 69–72, 78–80, §§190–191, 248–251; Hogg 1992, 112–14). The present formalization keeps those diphthongal outcomes visible as a distinct part of the general umlautal development and does not leave them implicit under the broad description of fronting.

Chronologically, this component also shares the same evidence as the umlaut complex as a whole. If the umlaut complex is moved before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization, it over-palatalizes **kūi* and **lúnganjō*; too-early West-Saxon diphthongization yields *gieft* and *scēþ* instead of expected *gift* and *scēap*. The rule therefore belongs between SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization. This places SC052 OEVelarPalatalization before SC055 OEIUmlautDiphthong, and it places SC055 OEIUmlautDiphthong before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization.

6.5 SC055. The composite i-umlaut rule (OEIUmlaut)

The implementation also defines a composite rule that composes the three preceding parts.

```

define OEIUmlaut OEIUmlautFronting
  .o. OEIUmlautRaising
  .o. OEIUmlautDiphthong;

```

In prose, this says that the implementation treats the umlaut as a sequence of fronting, raising, and diphthongal adjustments composed in order.

Chronologically, the composite rule must follow SC052 OEVelarPalatalization. If it is moved too early, forms such as *cȳ* ‘cows’ and *lungen* ‘lungs’ become over-palatalized. PGmc **kūi* yields *cȳ* ‘cows’; the expected form is *cȳ* ‘cows’. PGmc **lúnganjō* yields *lungen* ‘lungs’; the expected form is *lungen* ‘lungs’.

The same local network gives the later boundary. If West-Saxon palatal diphthongization is moved too early, PGmc **gēftiz* yields *gieft* ‘gift’ rather than expected OE *gift*, and **skáiθiz* yields *scēþ* ‘sheath’ rather than expected *scēap*. The composite umlaut rule therefore must apply after SC052 OEVelarPalatalization and before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization.

Those failures show that the broad umlautal rule needs an earlier terminus post quem in the palatalization sequence, even though it remains the main vowel change within the present chapter.

The composite rule is important because the literature presents the umlaut as a single historical development even while the implementation decomposes it into formal parts. The composite definition is the point at which the separate fronting, raising, and diphthongal effects are treated as one chronological event in the Old English sequence.

6.6 SC056. West Saxon palatal diphthongization (OEWsPalatalDiphthongization)

The narrower West-Saxon rule is treated separately from the broader umlautal complex.

```

define OEWsPalatalDiphthongization [
  { *æ } -> { *ea } || .#. [ { *tj } | { *θj } | { *fj } | { *j } ] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |
    ↪ EnglishPalatalConsonant | .#.],
  { *ǣ } -> { *ēa } || .#. [ { *tj } | { *θj } | { *fj } | { *j } ] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |
    ↪ EnglishPalatalConsonant | .#.],

```

```

{*e} -> {*ie} || .#. [{*tʃ} | {*θ} | {*ʃ} | {*j}] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |
↳ EnglishPalatalConsonant | .#.],
{*ē} -> {*ie} || .#. [{*tʃ} | {*θ} | {*ʃ} | {*j}] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |
↳ EnglishPalatalConsonant | .#.],
{*é} -> {*ie} || .#. [{*tʃ} | {*θ} | {*ʃ} | {*j}] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |
↳ EnglishPalatalConsonant | .#.],
{*ĕ} -> {*ie} || .#. [{*tʃ} | {*θ} | {*ʃ} | {*j}] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |
↳ EnglishPalatalConsonant | .#.]
];

```

In prose, this rule diphthongizes certain vowels after already palatal consonants in West Saxon. It therefore has a narrower dialectal and chronological scope than the broader umlaut rule.

The historical evidence for that narrower scope is concrete. Ringe and Taylor illustrate the rule with forms such as *gielðan* ‘pay’, *sciold* ‘shield’, and *scieppan* ‘create’, where an already palatal consonant triggers the diphthongal outcome (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 215–16, §6.5.1). Hogg’s *giefan* ‘give’ and *sceap* ‘sheep’ material belongs to the same phonological zone (Hogg 1992, 108–9), while Fulk distinguishes this palatal-consonant-triggered diphthongization from the broad front-mutation process (Fulk 2018, 74, §4.13).

Its place is later than SC055 OEIUmlaut. If this rule is moved too early, the later ordering is constrained by forms such as *ġift* ‘gift’ and *scēap* ‘sheath’. PGmc **gēftiz* then yields *ġieft* ‘gift’; the expected form is *ġift* ‘gift’. PGmc **skáiθiz* yields *scēap* ‘sheath’; the expected form is *scēap* ‘sheath’.

This shows that SC055 OEIUmlaut must come before SC056 OEWsPalatalDiphthongization. No comparably sharp later boundary is available.

No tested lexical item provides a comparably precise later terminus ante quem. The available evidence therefore establishes the rule’s relation to the earlier umlautal process much more clearly than it fixes a later point by which it must already have applied.

The two rules should accordingly be kept distinct. The broad umlautal rule accounts for a system-wide assimilatory change; the West-Saxon rule accounts for a narrower palatal-consonant-conditioned diphthongization whose chronological and dialectal scope is more restricted.

7 J-cluster coalescence

7.1 Historical discussion

This chapter belongs to the later part of the palatalization and fronting region. Campbell, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk all discuss the same neighborhood of palatalized and fronted outcomes that underlies forms such as *bīēgan* ‘bend’ and *sēcan* ‘seek’ (Campbell 1959, 89, 107–8, §§170, 248–251; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 213–51, §§6.4.1, 6.5.1, 6.6.1–6.6.4; Fulk 2018, 65, 75, §§4.7, 4.13). None of them turns this later cluster adjustment into a major independent headline. The historical interest lies in the fact that it remains a real part of the sequence even though the larger palatalization and umlaut chapters carry more of the explanatory weight.

That narrower scale matters. Earlier chapters have already established the plain velar and **sk* palatalizations, and the umlaut chapter has already handled the major vowel consequences. The present rule is a later coalescence inside that same neighborhood. It deserves explicit prose because the lexical outcomes are clear, not because it eclipses the larger processes around it.

7.2 SC057. Coalescence of velar + **j* clusters (OEJClusterCoalescence)

The implementation keeps the later cluster coalescence very small and explicit.

```
define OEJClusterCoalescence (  
  [{*g} {*j} -> {*ǵ}]  
  .o. [{*k} {*j} -> {*tʃ}]  
);
```

In prose, the rule coalesces **gj* and **kj* into the palatal outcomes that later surface in forms such as *bīēgan* ‘bend’ and *sēcan* ‘seek’.

Its earlier dependency is clearer than its later limit. If the rule is moved before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization, the developments behind *bīēgan* ‘bend’ and *sēcan* ‘seek’ are lost. Related forms such as *fylgan* ‘follow’, *hecg* ‘hedge’, and *sengan* ‘sing’ fail in the same broader palatalization zone. PGmc **bāugijana* yields *bēagan* ‘bend’ rather than expected OE *bīēgan*, and PGmc **sōkijana* yields *sōcan* ‘seek’ rather than expected *sēcan*. This shows that SC052 OEVelarPalatalization must come before SC057 OEJClusterCoalescence. No comparably sharp later lexical breakpoint emerges within the remaining sequence, so the chronology remains short and one-sided.

That modest shape is historically appropriate. The rule is a real later member of the palatalization region, but it does not need to absorb the umlaut chapter behind it or the nasal-dissimilation chapter that follows it. The later coalescence remains visible in the sequence once the larger neighboring chapters are already in place.

8 Nasal dissimilation

8.1 Historical discussion

Luick preserves individual outcomes such as *enetre* ‘yearling’ (with the spelling *enitre* in his text) without isolating a separate law around them (Luick 1914–1940, 166). Campbell likewise reaches forms such as *heofon* ‘heaven’ in a discussion of suffixal variation and does not set them off in any special section on nasal dissimilation (Campbell 1959, 155). Hogg mentions *heofon* ‘heaven’ in the course of his account of back mutation, again without isolating a separate law (Hogg 1992, 112).

Fulk supplies the clearest general formulation: “In the cluster *mn*, the first consonant tends to lose its nasality by dissimilation, though the results are hardly regular” (Fulk 2018, 121, §6.11). Ringe and Taylor stay close to the lexical evidence and note that *enetre* ‘yearling’ reflects “loss of the second **n* by dissimilation” (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 282).

The discussion therefore develops from scattered lexical observations to a more explicit but still cautious generalization. Luick preserves the kind of form the rule is meant to capture. Campbell and Hogg show that related outcomes enter the handbooks, but only incidentally, as part of larger accounts of other changes. Fulk makes the recurrent *mn* tendency explicit, while Ringe and Taylor provide an exact lexical case in *enetre* ‘yearling’. What emerges is a limited but recurring dissimilatory pattern whose scope is far smaller than that of the major Old English vowel laws.

8.2 SC058. Nasal dissimilation in short-vowel environments (OENasalDissimilation)

The implementation formalizes the change as a narrow rule applying in short vowel environments before a following *n*.

```
define OENasalDissimilation [  
  {*m} -> {*f} || EnglishStarShortVowel _ EnglishStarShortVowel {*n}  
  ↪ [EnglishStarShortVowel | .#.]  
];
```

In plain language, the rule turns medial *m* into *f* in a restricted short-vowel environment before a following syllable containing *n*.

Historically, the rule captures the limited type of dissimilation reflected in forms such as *heofon* ‘heaven’, *fæstenn* ‘fasting’, and *enetre* ‘yearling’. It is much narrower than the major vowel changes and is best understood as a recurring but partly lexicalized pattern.

The relation between the sources and the formalization is correspondingly close but not exact. Fulk formulates the tendency at the level of *mn* clusters and illustrates it with *heofon* ‘heaven’ and *fæstenn* ‘fasting’ (Fulk 2018, 121, §6.11). Ringe and Taylor show the same kind of development in *enetre* ‘yearling’ (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 282). Campbell’s “*heofon* is for older *hefzen*” and Hogg’s sequence **hefon* > *heofon* preserve outcomes of the same kind as those modeled here (Campbell 1959, 155; Hogg 1992, 112). The formal rule is therefore narrower than the total set of handbook remarks: it models one plausible recurrent environment and does not claim to exhaust every dissimilatory development involving nasals.

Chronologically, the available tests do not identify a sharper position within the Old English sequence. When the rule is moved earlier, no lexical breakpoint appears before the inherited West-Germanic material that precedes the tested Old English changes. When it is moved later, the tests likewise fail to identify a more precise later boundary within the remainder of the Old English sequence.

No comparable pair of lexical failures fixes a narrower slot here. The present evidence therefore gives neither a precise terminus post quem nor a precise terminus ante quem for the rule within the tested sequence. No exact wrong early or late output is currently available for this chapter.

Even so, the rule has real interpretative consequences. It provides a place in the implementation for outcomes of the *heofon* ‘heaven’, *fæstenn* ‘fasting’, and *enetre* ‘yearling’ type discussed in the

literature (Fulk 2018, 121, §6.11; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 282; Campbell 1959, 155; Luick 1914-1940, 166; Hogg 1992, 112). Without an explicit rule, those outcomes would be left to diffuse analogy or to unexplained exception lists.

The evidence points to a narrow dissimilatory tendency, especially in *mn*-type clusters and a small group of lexical outcomes. There is no support for a regular change operating across a broad phonological field. The rule is secure enough to model, but the available tests leave its position within the Old English sequence underdetermined.

9 Back mutation

9.1 Historical discussion

Back mutation is the substantive center of this part of the sequence. Campbell treats it as a later Old English diphthongizing development before following back vowels, and his examples already show why forms such as *heofon* ‘heaven’ are historically legible outcomes in their own right (Campbell 1959, 86, §207). Hogg treats the same development as a later change with clear parallels to breaking (Hogg 1992, 112). Ringe and Taylor sharpen the picture by distinguishing West Saxon forms such as *giefan* ‘give’ and *wefan* ‘weave’ from non-West-Saxon forms such as *geofad* and *weofan* (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 319, §6.9.4). Fulk likewise treats back mutation as a distinct historical phenomenon with its own profile beside the earlier umlautal changes (Fulk 2018, 69, §4.8).

That makes back mutation different from the short notes that follow it. Back mutation belongs to the same local stretch of the sequence, but it carries more historical weight and clearer lexical consequences. Even so, its later relation lies beyond this immediate stretch of the sequence, and the later weak-tail region is best kept as a forward reference only.

9.2 SC059. Back mutation before labials and liquids (OEBackMutation)

The implementation keeps the change as one explicit rule.

```
define OEBackMutation [  
  {*e} -> {*eo} || _ [EnglishStarLabial | EnglishStarLiquid] {*u},  
  {*æ} -> {*ea} || _ [EnglishStarLabial | EnglishStarLiquid]  
  ↪ EnglishBackMutationTrigger,  
  {*é} -> {*éo} || _ [EnglishStarLabial | EnglishStarLiquid] {*u}  
];
```

In prose, the rule backs and diphthongizes earlier front vowels before a following labial or liquid plus a back-vocalic trigger.

Its chronology is real on both sides, but not equally local. The earlier side is already fixed by the preceding vowel and weak-tail material. If the rule is moved too early, forms such as **gébanq* produce *geofan* ‘give’; the expected form is *giefan* ‘give’. **stélanq* likewise produces *steolan* ‘steal’; the expected form is *stelan* ‘steal’. The later side is different. If the rule is pushed too far to the right, **wébanq* yields *weofan* ‘weave’; the expected form is *wefan* ‘weave’. That later edge is real, but it points beyond the present stretch of the sequence into the later weak-tail reductions, so here it should remain only a forward reference.

These lexical failures show that SC048 OESecondaryNasalization must come before SC059 OEBackMutation and that SC059 OEBackMutation must come before SC078 OEWeakTailReduction.

This is why the change can serve as the center here without implying that the following weak-tail notes belong to the same historical law. The rule marks a real local seam, but the section after it immediately becomes narrower.

10 West Saxon palatal umlaut

10.1 Historical discussion

The evidence is narrow enough that the discussion can stay brief. Campbell and Ringe and Taylor both support the development behind forms such as *miht* ‘might’ and *niht* ‘night’, while Fulk’s broader chronology makes clear that this material belongs beside the umlaut and palatal-vowel region as a subordinate note beside it (Campbell 1959, 107–8, §§248–251; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 215–51, §§6.5.1, 6.6.1–6.6.4; Fulk 2018, 65, 75, §§4.7, 4.13).

That is why the note belongs here after back mutation even though its clearest historical tie still reaches back to the earlier umlaut chapter. The phenomenon is real, yet its place in the sequence is one-sided. The evidence is clear enough to state and narrow enough to remain brief.

10.2 SC060. West Saxon palatal umlaut before **h*-clusters (OEWsPalatalUmlaut)

The implementation treats the West Saxon change as one explicit rule.

```
define OEWsPalatalUmlaut [  
  {*eo} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster .#.,  
  {*io} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster .#.,  
  {*ie} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster .#.,  
  {*eo} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster EnglishStarFrontVowel,  
  {*io} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster EnglishStarFrontVowel,  
  {*ie} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster EnglishStarFrontVowel,  
  {*éo} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster .#.,  
  {*ío} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster .#.,  
  {*íe} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster .#.,  
  {*éo} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster EnglishStarFrontVowel,  
  {*ío} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster EnglishStarFrontVowel,  
  {*íe} -> {*i} || _ OEHCluster EnglishStarFrontVowel  
];
```

In prose, the rule reduces short diphthongs to **i* before the relevant **h* clusters.

The crucial point is its earlier dependency. The rule must follow SC055 OEIUmlaut, because if it is moved too early the forms behind *miht* ‘might’ and *niht* ‘night’ remain at the overdeveloped stage *mieht* and *nieht* rather than expected OE *miht* and *niht*. No comparably sharp later lexical breakpoint emerges within the remainder of the section. The note therefore belongs here as a short afterpiece to the umlaut chapter, not as the start of a new larger unit.

This shows that SC055 OEIUmlaut must come before SC060 OEWsPalatalUmlaut. No comparably sharp later boundary is available.

11 Weak-tail nasal loss

11.1 Historical discussion

The development belongs to the narrower end of the later weak-tail sequence. It is historically legible through the pathway that leads to *dōn* ‘do’, and the broader late weak-tail setting is supported by the usual handbook discussions of apocope and related reduction (Campbell 1959, 144–45, §§345–349; Hogg 1992, 120–21; Fulk 2018, 91, §5.6). But the decisive lexical tie lies much farther back in the sequence, in the older development of **dōnq*. That keeps the note real, while also keeping it small.

Within this later run of changes it follows back mutation and West Saxon palatal umlaut, but the evidence remains slighter than theirs.

11.2 SC061. Reduction of final nasal weak-tail endings (OEWeakTailNasalLoss)

The implementation keeps the change as one short rule.

```
define OEWeakTailNasalLoss [  
  {*n} {*a} -> {*n} || _ .#.,  
  {*m} {*a} -> {*m} || _ .#.  
];
```

In prose, the rule reduces final weak-tail endings of the type **-nq* and **-mq* to plain final **-n* and **-m*.

The clearest lexical witness is the pathway to *dōn* ‘do’. If the rule is moved too early, before the older reduction that already shapes the **dōnq* sequence, the derivation records no output instead of expected OE *dōn* ‘do’. No equally sharp later breakpoint appears within the tested sequence. That is why the note remains one-sided and why its earlier relation should be understood as a distant cross-reference only and should not reshape the broader sequence.

This shows that SC023 NWGmcNStemNLoss must come before SC061 OEWeakTailNasalLoss. No comparably sharp later boundary is available.

The development is best treated as a small late weak-tail adjustment. It remains visible in the sequence because it affects the pathway to *dōn* ‘do’, but the evidence does not support treating it as the center of a wider historical development.

12 High-vowel apocope

12.1 Historical discussion

By this point in the sequence the main palatal and umlautal changes are already in place, but weak-tail reduction is not finished. Final high vowels still survive in many forms until a late apocope removes them after heavy syllables and in the relevant trisyllabic patterns. Campbell, Hogg, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk all describe this as a real Old English development, even when they differ over how much of the surrounding syncope material should be grouped with it (Campbell 1959, 144–45, §§345–349; Hogg 1992, 120; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 284–303, §§6.8.1, 6.8.4; Fulk 2018, 91, §5.6).

The rule matters because it makes many familiar Old English forms look abruptly shorter than their earlier stages. It is also a good place to show how finite-state chronology works. The derivation can say exactly which forms fail if apocope is moved too early or too late, so the late weak-tail sequence becomes visible through concrete lexical breakpoints and explicit ordering statements.

12.2 SC063. High-vowel apocope after heavy syllables and in trisyllables (OEHighVowelApocope)

The implementation keeps the whole apocope system in one explicit rule.

```
define OEHighVowelApocope [  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+  
    ↳ EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+  
    ↳ EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+  
    ↳ EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortDiphthong OEAnyConsonant EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant EnglishStarShortVowel  
    ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,
```

```

{*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant EnglishStarShortVowel
  ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,
{*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant EnglishStarShortVowel
  ↳ OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,
{*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+
  ↳ EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,
{*u} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+
  ↳ EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,
{*y} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+
  ↳ EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ .#.,
{*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel _ .#.,
{*u} -> 0 || {*x} _ .#.,
{*y} -> 0 || {*x} _ .#.,
{*i} -> 0 || {*x} _ .#.
];

```

In prose, the rule deletes final **i*, **u*, and **y* when the preceding structure is heavy enough, or when a trisyllabic form behaves as equivalent to a heavy environment. The longer code box makes visible how many separate environments the transducer has to distinguish in order to realize what the handbooks describe more compactly.

Its chronology is explicit on both sides. If the rule is moved before SC055 OEIUmlaut, PGmc **kūi* yields *cū* rather than expected OE *cý* ‘cow’, and PGmc **brūdiz* yields *brūd* rather than expected OE *brýd* ‘bride’. If the rule is delayed until after SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening, PGmc **fūrxtīnaz* yields *fyrht* rather than expected OE *fyrhte* ‘fright’. This means that SC055 OEIUmlaut must come before SC063 OEHighVowelApocope, and that SC063 OEHighVowelApocope must come before SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening.

That placement is historically apt. The rule must come late enough for umlautal effects to have already been created, but it is not the last weak-tail event in the language. Apocope removes a major set of final high vowels, yet later weak-tail reductions still remain.

13 Post-apocope **n*-loss and medial syncope

13.1 Historical discussion of post-apocope **n*-loss and medial syncope

After high-vowel apocope the weak tail is still not entirely settled. Hogg, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk all describe a late region in which further medial reduction and cluster pressure remain active, even though the evidence is much less even than it was for the main apocope rule (Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 264–303, §§6.7.3–6.8.4; Fulk 2018, 91, §5.6). The inherited **furht-* family adds one especially narrow witness of its own, because it shows that a single surviving nasal can still decide whether the weak-tail output is right or wrong (Kroonen 2013, 201).

This chapter is therefore intentionally modest. One rule has real positive chronology on both sides, but only through a single witness family. The other belongs naturally to the same late region without yet producing a comparably sharp first-break result. Keeping both visible makes the weak-tail aftermath more honest than either silence or overstatement would.

13.2 SC064. Loss of stem-final **n* after long **ī* (NWGmcInStemNLoss)

The first rule is extremely narrow in form.

```
define NWGmcInStemNLoss [{*n} -> 0 || {*ī} _ .#.];
```

In prose, it removes a final **n* after long **ī*. That looks tiny on the page, but the effect is real in the inherited family behind *fyrhte* ‘fright’.

The chronology is two-sided even though the witness base is not broad. If the rule is moved before SC041 PWGmcFinalBareALoss, PGmc **fūrxtīnaz* yields *fyrhten* rather than expected OE *fyrhte* ‘fright’. If the rule is delayed until after SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening, the same PGmc form again yields *fyrhten* rather than expected *fyrhte*. This shows that SC041 PWGmcFinalBareALoss must come before SC064 NWGmcInStemNLoss, and it places SC064 NWGmcInStemNLoss before SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening.

That symmetry does not make the rule large. Both boundaries are carried by the same witness family, so the evidence is real but narrow. The value of the rule lies in showing that even a very small formal step can still have a concrete lexical place in the chronology.

13.3 SC065. Medial syncope before dentals after heavy syllables (OEMedialSyncope)

The second rule formalizes one narrower slice of late medial syncope.

```
define OEMedialSyncope [  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ [{*θ}|{*ð}|{*d}|{*t}],  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ _ [{*θ}|{*ð}|{*d}|{*t}],  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant OEAnyConsonant+ _  
    ↳ [{*θ}|{*ð}|{*d}|{*t}]  
];
```

In prose, it deletes medial **i* before a following dental after a heavy syllable. The broader historical background is secure enough, since the handbooks do treat late medial syncope as part of the same weak-tail region (Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 264–303, §§6.7.3–6.8.4; Fulk 2018, 91, §5.6).

The finite-state chronology is much weaker, however. If the rule is moved earlier, the current tests find no real break before the search reaches bundled earlier material. If the rule is delayed, the tests likewise find no real break before the current search boundary. No exact wrong early or late output is currently available, so this section remains boundary-limited and does not claim a sharper relation than the evidence supports.

That limitation is worth stating plainly. Late medial syncope belongs in the history of the weak tail, but this particular rule does not yet fix an earlier boundary or a later boundary of its own.

14 Late syncope and degemination

14.1 Historical discussion of late syncope and degemination

Once later medial syncope begins to bite, the language inherits new consonant clusters that do not always remain stable. Hogg and Ringe and Taylor both describe this connection between vowel loss and later consonant simplification, while Brunner’s discussion of *netle* ‘nettle’ beside later *nete* keeps the syncope evidence tied to a concrete lexical type (Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 264–96, §§6.7.3–6.8.2; Sievers 1965, 144–45, §§158–159). Fulk is especially useful for the larger timing, because he places this syncope after i-umlaut (Fulk 2018, 91, §5.6).

The resulting chapter has an uneven center of gravity. Syncope itself is well motivated, one downstream degemination rule has a clear lexical breakpoint, and the dental assimilation step between them is plausible without yet being independently well anchored. That imbalance is part of the point. The sequence shows how the transducer can make a narrow chain of consequences explicit without pretending that every member has the same evidential weight.

14.2 SC066. L-adjacent syncope in medial syllables (OELAdjacentSyncope)

The syncope rule is stated directly.

```
define OELAdjacentSyncope [  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarShortVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ {*l},  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarLongVowel OEAnyConsonant+ _ {*l},  
  {*i} -> 0 || EnglishStarDiphthong OEAnyConsonant+ _ {*l}  
];
```

In prose, it deletes medial **i* before **l*, creating forms such as *netle* ‘nettle’ and *spinl* ‘spindle’.

Its chronology is explicit on both sides. If the rule is moved before SC055 OEIUmlaut, PGmc **nátílōn* yields *nætle* rather than expected OE *netle* ‘nettle’, and PGmc **spénnilō* yields *spenl* rather than expected *spinl* ‘spindle’. If the rule is delayed until after SC068 OEPreconsonantalDegemination, PGmc **spénnilō* yields *spinnl* rather than expected *spinl*. This shows that SC055 OEIUmlaut must come before SC066 OELAdjacentSyncope, and that SC066 OELAdjacentSyncope must come before SC068 OEPreconsonantalDegemination.

The rule is therefore stronger than a mere descriptive convenience. It has concrete lexical witnesses, and those witnesses show that the syncope must stand after umlaut but before later cluster simplification.

14.3 SC067. Dental assimilation in newly formed clusters (OEDentalAssimilation)

The dental repair step is formally very short.

```
define OEDentalAssimilation [  
  {*θ} -> 0 || {*t} _  
];
```

In prose, it removes **θ* after **t* when syncope has created an over-heavy dental cluster. That kind of cluster simplification is historically plausible as part of the same late sequence that follows syncope (Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 279–96, §§6.7.5, 6.8.2).

The chronology tests, however, do not yet isolate a positive earlier boundary or a positive later boundary for this rule. If the rule is moved earlier, the search reaches bundled earlier material without a real break. If it is delayed, the search likewise reaches the current search boundary without a real break. No exact wrong early or late output is currently available, so the section remains boundary-limited.

That makes the rule best read as a narrow intermediate step inside the late syncope sequence. It is useful in the derivation, but the present evidence does not justify treating it as a stronger chronology anchor than it is.

14.4 SC068. Preconsonantal degemination before sonorants (OEPreconsonantalDegemination)

The final degemination rule is written as one composed definition.

```
define OEPreconsonantalDegemination OEPreconsonantalDegemTT .o.  
  ⇨ OEPreconsonantalDegemNN;
```

In prose, it simplifies doubled **tt* or **nn* before a following sonorant. The historical logic is straightforward enough. Once syncope has created a cluster such as the one behind *spinl* ‘spindle’, the doubled consonant does not remain (Ringe and Taylor 2014, 279–96, §§6.7.5, 6.8.2).

Its positive evidence is one-sided but exact. If the rule is moved before SC066 OELAdjacentSyncope, PGmc **spénnilō* yields *spinnl* rather than expected OE *spinl* ‘spindle’. No later real break is currently available before the current search boundary. This places SC066 OELAdjacentSyncope before SC068 OEPreconsonantalDegemination, while the later side remains one-sided.

That one-sided profile is still meaningful. The rule is clearly later than the syncope that creates the offending cluster, but the current evidence does not yet force a sharper later boundary beyond that.

15 Early o-shortening

15.1 Historical discussion

By the time the sequence reaches this point, the language has already undergone the larger palatal andumlautal reorganizations to the left. What now comes into view is a later weak-tail region in which unstressed vowels are shortened, fronted, merged, and in some forms lost altogether. Campbell’s discussion of early shortening of unaccented long vowels helps place this material in the larger history, while Hogg, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk all describe the same late region through the intertwined history of apocope, syncope, shortening, and later reductions (Campbell 1959, 148, §355; Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 298–314, §§6.8.3–6.9.3; Fulk 2018, 90–96, §§5.6–5.7).

Early o-shortening belongs at the opening of that region, but it is not its strongest hinge. The evidence is broader and more distant than it is for the rules that follow, especially SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly and SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening. The rule therefore works best as an opening note that makes the chronology legible without pretending that the whole late weak tail begins and ends here.

15.2 SC069. Early shortening of unstressed *ō before nasals (OEEarlyOShortening)

The implementation isolates the early shortening step as one rule.

```
define OEEarlyOShortening [  
  { *ō } -> { *a } || EnglishStarVocalic [EnglishStarConsonant |  
    ↪ EnglishPalatalConsonant]+ _ EnglishStarNasal  
];
```

In prose, the rule shortens unstressed long *ō before a following nasal. Because this shortening happens early, the resulting *a can still participate in the later fronting and merger that shape many weak final syllables.

Its chronology is real, but it is broad and one-sided. If the rule is moved before SC023 NWGmcNStemNLoss, PGmc **nēdrōn* yields *nædran* rather than expected OE *nædre* ‘adder’, PGmc **érθōn* yields *eorþan* rather than expected *eorþe* ‘earth’, and PGmc **fláskōn* yields *flascan* rather than expected *flasce* ‘flask’. The same earlier shift also disrupts forms such as *heorte* ‘heart’ and *līne* ‘line’. This broad set of failures shows that SC023 NWGmcNStemNLoss must come before SC069 OEEarlyOShortening.

No equally sharp later breakpoint appears within the tested range. The current search reaches its later boundary without a real break, so the rule should not be given a spurious later limit. Early o-shortening is therefore best read as an opening adjustment in the late weak tail, not as the central chronology seam of the region.

16 Early unstressed fronting and later o-shortening

16.1 Historical discussion of early unstressed fronting and later o-shortening

The next pair forms a clearer local hinge. Campbell’s account of shortening of unaccented long vowels is still relevant here, but the real value of the pair lies in the way the finite-state derivation separates an earlier fronting stage from a later shortening stage. Hogg, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk all place these developments inside the same late weak-tail region in which shortening, syncope, and final-vowel adjustment continue to interact (Campbell 1959, 148, §355; Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 298–314, §§6.8.3–6.9.3; Fulk 2018, 90–96, §§5.6–5.7).

The hierarchy inside the pair is not flat. SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly is the stronger hinge because it has an earlier and a later lexical breakpoint. SC071 OELateOShortening confirms the same seam from the right, but its later side remains open within the tested range. That imbalance is historically useful: it shows how the late weak tail is held together by small but concrete lexical breakpoints, not by one single undifferentiated rule.

16.2 SC070. Early fronting of unstressed *a (OEUnstressedFrontingEarly)

The implementation gives the early fronting stage its own named step.

```
define OEUnstressedFrontingEarly OEUnstressedAFronting;
```

In prose, the rule fronts unstressed *a to *æ at the point where the earlier shortening has already created a frontable vowel, but the later shortening of unstressed *ō has not yet happened. This is the step that makes endings such as OE *-en* possible in forms like *lungen* ‘lungs’.

Its chronology is explicit on both sides. If the rule is moved before SC052 OEVelarPalatalization, PGmc **lúnganjō* yields *lunġen* rather than expected OE *lungen* ‘lungs’. If the rule is delayed until after SC071 OELateOShortening, PGmc **búrōθi* yields *boreþ* rather than expected OE *borap* ‘bears’, and PGmc **mēnōθz* yields *mōneþ* rather than expected *mōnaþ* ‘month’. This shows that SC052 OEVelarPalatalization must come before SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly, and that SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly must come before SC071 OELateOShortening.

That two-sided pattern is why SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly serves as the real hinge of the pair. The earlier side is narrow, but the later side produces a coherent set of wrong unstressed vowels across several verbal and nominal endings.

16.3 SC071. Later shortening of unstressed *ō (OELateOShortening)

The following rule handles the later shortening stage.

```
define OELateOShortening [  
  { *ō } -> { *a } || EnglishStarVocalic [EnglishStarConsonant |  
    ↪ EnglishPalatalConsonant]+ _ [EnglishStarConsonant |  
    ↪ EnglishPalatalConsonant]*  
];
```

In prose, the rule shortens the remaining unstressed long *ō after the earlier fronting stage has already done its work. This is the stage that leaves the later “stable a” endings behind forms such as OE *borap* ‘bears’ and *liornaþ* ‘learns’.

Its earlier boundary is the reciprocal side of the SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly relation. If the rule is moved before SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly, PGmc **búrōθi* yields *boreþ* rather than expected OE *borap*, and PGmc **líznoθi* yields *liorneþ* rather than expected *liornaþ*. No equally sharp later breakpoint appears within the tested range, so the available evidence shows only that SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly must come before SC071 OELateOShortening.

This one-sided profile is appropriate to the chapter. SC071 OELateOShortening is a real follower in the same pair, but it does not need to carry more chronology than the evidence supports.

17 Unstressed long-vowel shortening and ae-merger

17.1 Historical discussion of unstressed long-vowel shortening and ae-merger

This pair is the strongest internal seam in the late weak tail. Campbell’s discussion of shortening of unaccented long vowels gives the classical background, while Ringe and Taylor place shortening of unstressed long vowels among the last prehistoric Old English changes and then carry the story forward into the immediately following developments (Campbell 1959, 148, §355; Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 298–314, §§6.8.3–6.9.3; Fulk 2018, 90–96, §§5.6–5.7). What the finite-state derivation adds is a very sharp distinction between the shortening itself and the later merger of unstressed *æ with *e.

That is why this chapter can be more substantial than the opening note or the earlier pair. SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening and SC073 OEUnstressedAEMerger have a real reciprocal relation in the cards, and the chapter can show both sides of it directly. The pair also keeps its outward relations in view: SC064 NWGmcInStemNLoss remains the earlier prerequisite for shortening, while SC085 OEHLoss remains the later outward handoff from the merger.

17.2 SC072. Shortening of unstressed long vowels (OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening)

The implementation keeps the shortening stage as one composed rule.

```
define OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening1
  .o. OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening2
  .o. OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening3
  .o. OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening5
  .o. OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening6
  .o. OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening7
  .o. OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening8;
```

In prose, the rule shortens the remaining unstressed long vowels before the weak final outcomes settle into their later forms. The broad effect is visible in many weak endings, but the chronology can still be pinned down by a few particularly clear witnesses.

Its chronology is explicit on both sides. If the rule is moved before SC064 NWGmcInStemNLoss, PGmc *fūrxtinaz yields *fyrhten* rather than expected OE *fyrhte* ‘fright’. If the rule is delayed until after SC073 OEUnstressedAEMerger, PGmc *nédrōn yields *nædræ* rather than expected OE *nædre* ‘adder’, and PGmc *fādēr yields *fædær* rather than expected *fæder* ‘father’. This shows that SC064 NWGmcInStemNLoss must come before SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening, and that SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening must come before SC073 OEUnstressedAEMerger.

That two-sided relation makes SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening the historical center of the pair. It still depends on earlier weak-tail preparation to the left, but within the local chapter it is the shortening stage that creates the strongest seam.

17.3 SC073. Merger of unstressed *æ with *e (OEUnstressedAEMerger)

The following rule handles the merger stage.

```
define OEUnstressedAEMerger OEWeakTailReduction3;
```

In prose, the rule merges unstressed *æ with *e after shortening has already produced the vulnerable weak final vowels. This is the stage that turns a broad set of final outcomes toward the ordinary OE -e spellings.

Its earlier and later relations are both concrete. If the rule is moved before SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening, PGmc *nédrōn yields *nædræ* rather than expected OE *nædre*, and PGmc *fādēr yields *fædær* rather than expected *fæder*. If the rule is delayed until after SC085 OEHLoss,

PGmc **táixōn* yields *tāæ* rather than expected OE *tā* ‘toe’. This means that SC072 OEUnstressed-LongVowelShortening must come before SC073 OEUnstressedAEMerger, and that SC073 OEUnstressedAEMerger must come before SC085 OEHLoss.

The earlier side is broader than the later side, but both are real. That is why this pair works as the strongest local core in the late weak tail. Shortening and merger are adjacent, reciprocal, and still open to meaningful outward cross-reference without having to absorb later material into the chapter.

18 Medial unstressed-i lowering

18.1 Historical discussion of medial unstressed-i lowering and **ng* retention

The next pair belongs to the same late weak-tail region as the shortening and merger chapter to the left, but it is smaller and more locally conditioned. Hogg and Ringe and Taylor both treat the late weakening and merger of unstressed vowels as part of a continuing history, and that background helps explain why the present chapter reads best as a narrow follow-on, not a new center of gravity (Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 327–32, §§6.9.5–6.9.6). The specific value of the pair is derivational. SC074 OMedUnstressedILowering1 generalizes a medial unstressed-*i* lowering, while SC075 OMedUnstressedILowering immediately narrows that result by preserving *i* before **ng* in words of the *scilling* ‘shilling’ type.

That close interaction is why the two rules still belong in one small chapter. The history is not simply adjacency in the cascade. The second rule directly repairs the overbroad outcome that the first would otherwise leave behind in the **ng* environment. Even so, the pair remains narrower and more witness-limited than SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening and SC073 OEUnstressedAEMerger.

18.2 SC074. First medial unstressed-*i* lowering (OMedUnstressedILowering1)

The implementation gives the first lowering step its own rule.

```
define OMedUnstressedILowering1 [  
  {*i} -> {*e} || EnglishStarVocalic [EnglishStarConsonant |  
    ↳ EnglishPalatalConsonant]+ _  
];
```

In prose, the rule lowers medial unstressed **i* to **e* after a preceding vocalic syllable. This is the broader step that would spread the *e*-outcome through the late weak tail if it were left uncorrected.

Its chronology is explicit on both sides. If the rule is moved before SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening, PGmc **fúrxtīnaz* yields *fyrhti* rather than expected OE *fyrhte* ‘fright’. If it is delayed until after SC075 OMedUnstressedILowering, PGmc **skillingaz* yields *scilleng* rather than expected *scilling* ‘shilling’. This shows that SC072 OEUnstressedLongVowelShortening must come before SC074 OMedUnstressedILowering1, and that SC074 OMedUnstressedILowering1 must come before SC075 OMedUnstressedILowering.

The evidence is narrow on each side, but it is still real. The rule belongs between the stronger shortening/merger chapter and the more specific **ng* preservation that follows it.

18.3 SC075. Preservation of medial unstressed **i* before **ng* (OMedUnstressedILowering2)

The following rule gives the local **ng* restriction its own explicit step.

```
define OMedUnstressedILowering [  
  {*e} -> {*i} || _ {*n} {*g}  
];
```

In prose, the rule restores **i* before **ng*, preventing the broader lowering from producing the wrong medial vowel in forms such as *scilling* ‘shilling’.

Its earlier boundary is the reciprocal side of the SC074 OMedUnstressedILowering1 relation. If the rule is moved before SC074 OMedUnstressedILowering1, PGmc **skillingaz* yields *scilleng* rather than expected OE *scilling*. No equally sharp later breakpoint appears within the tested range, so the available evidence shows only that SC074 OMedUnstressedILowering1 must come before SC075 OMedUnstressedILowering.

That one-sided profile is enough for a follower rule of this kind. It is historically useful because it keeps the **ng* forms from being swallowed by the broader lowering, but it does not need to carry more chronology than the evidence supplies.

19 Prefix i-reduction

19.1 Historical discussion

Late weak-tail reduction does not affect only inflectional endings and medial vowels. Unstressed prefixes also weaken, and that smaller development deserves a visible place in the sequence even though its chronology is much less sharply fixed. Fulk is the clearest source here, since his discussion of vowels in prefixes makes forms like OE **be-* and **ne-* historically legible outcomes in their own right (Fulk 2018, 97, §5.7). Hogg and Ringe and Taylor supply the broader late environment in which such weakening belongs, even though they do not isolate this rule as a major center of the late-tail history (Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 298–332, §§6.8.3–6.9.6).

That is enough for a short note, but not for a major chronology anchor. Prefix reduction belongs in the late weak tail, yet the current tests do not recover a positive earlier boundary or a positive later boundary for this specific rule.

19.2 SC076. Reduction of prefixal **i* in unstressed position (OEPrefixIReduction)

The implementation keeps the prefixal reduction as one rule.

```
define OEPrefixIReduction [  
  {*i} -> {*ë} || .#. [{*b} | {*n}] _ [EnglishStarConsonant |  
    ↳ EnglishPalatalConsonant] EnglishStarVocalic  
];
```

In prose, the rule reduces unstressed prefixal **i* to a weaker vowel in the *bi-* and *ni-* type prefixes before a consonant plus a following vowel. This is the development that helps make later prefix spellings such as OE **be-* and **ne-* historically intelligible.

The chronology evidence is boundary-limited on both sides. If the rule is moved earlier, the current tests do not find a real lexical break before the search reaches bundled earlier material. If the rule is delayed, they do not find a real lexical break before the tested range ends at SC087 OERMetathesis. No exact wrong early or late output is currently available, so the prose does not claim a sharper ordering relation than the evidence supports.

That modest result is still useful. The rule has historical legitimacy from the prefix-vowel literature, but its place in the sequence remains a bounded methodological note, not a positive lexical hinge.

20 Weak-tail reduction

20.1 Historical discussion

The last rule in the present late weak-tail cluster is stronger than the small prefix note that precedes it. Campbell, Hogg, Ringe and Taylor, and Fulk all support a late region in which apocope, shortening, contraction, and further weak-tail reductions continue to reshape final syllables (Campbell 1959, 148, §355; Hogg 1992, 120–21; Ringe and Taylor 2014, 298–314, §§6.8.3–6.9.3; Fulk 2018, 90–91, §5.6). What makes the present rule stand out is that the finite-state chronology gives it a real boundary on both sides.

That does not make it a license to absorb later material. The later relation to SC086 OEContraction is meaningful, but it remains a cross-reference to the next cluster, not a reason to pull that cluster into the present chapter.

20.2 SC078. Reduction of remaining weak-tail vowels (OEWeakTailReduction)

The implementation keeps the last weak-tail reduction as one explicit step.

```
define OEWeakTailReduction OEWeakTailReduction1;
```

In prose, the rule carries the remaining weak-tail reductions that prevent a broad class of spurious *-en* or extra-vowel outcomes from surviving too late in the derivation.

Its chronology is real on both sides, though the two sides are not equally local. If the rule is moved before SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly, PGmc **bákaną* yields *bacen* rather than expected OE *bacan* ‘bake’, and PGmc **bīdaną* yields *binden* rather than expected *bindan* ‘bind’, alongside a much wider set of comparable *-en* failures. If the rule is delayed until after SC086 OEContraction, PGmc **fléuxaną* yields *flēoan* rather than expected OE *flēon* ‘flee’, and PGmc **sláxaną* yields *sleaan* rather than expected *slēan* ‘slay’. This shows that SC070 OEUnstressedFrontingEarly must come before SC078 OEWeakTailReduction, and that SC078 OEWeakTailReduction must come before SC086 OEContraction.

The asymmetry of those two boundaries is important. The earlier side is broad and should be read as a large computational limit, not a tight local adjacency claim. The later side is narrower and more directly interpretable. Together they make SC078 OEWeakTailReduction substantial enough for its own chapter, but still not a reason to merge the next cluster into the present section.

21 References

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